

# “FRANCE HAS LOST THE BATTLE, BUT FRANCE HAS NOT LOST THE WAR.”

Charles de Gaulle, French General, June 18, 1940

German troops march down the Champs Élysées after the occupation of Paris in June 1940. The French capital was an open city and taken without fighting.

launched an emotional plea for continued resistance, but few heeded the call. Pétain sought an **armistice**, which was **agreed on June 22**. At Hitler's insistence, the armistice was signed in the same railroad car in which the 1918 armistice had been signed.

German troops occupied the north and west of France. Pétain established a regime in the town of **Vichy** that held responsibility for all of France, although policy in the occupied part had to be agreed with the Germans. Taking almost dictatorial powers as head of state, he affirmed conservative principles of religion, patriotism, and the family. The **Vichy French collaborated** on some points with the Nazis, introducing their own anti-Semitic laws.

In **Britain**, Churchill quashed defeatism. He encouraged a popular **mood of defiance** with his broadcast speeches and pushed through radical measures to stiffen resistance. These ranged from the internment of aliens to the creation of the **Home Guard** militia to resist German invasion.

Since the British refused to negotiate a peace deal, Hitler began preparing a cross-Channel

## 449 THE NUMBER OF GERMAN BOMBERS INVOLVED IN THE 10-HOUR RAID ON THE BRITISH CITY OF COVENTRY

invasion. In August, the Luftwaffe began a sustained air campaign over southern England, initiating the **Battle of Britain**. British air defenses were well prepared, with radar early warning stations linked to command centers that coordinated a response by Spitfire and Hurricane fighters. Despite this, RAF

Fighter Command was hard pressed as waves of bombers with fighter escort attacked airfields, radar stations, and aircraft factories. It was a relief for the RAF when the Luftwaffe switched to **bombing London** from early September. On September 15, attacked by over 1,000 German aircraft, the British shot down 60 for the loss of 28 of their own. Such figures meant that Germany could not win the command of the air needed to cover an invasion.

German invasion plans were abandoned in October, but from autumn 1940 until May 1941, British cities were **subjected to the Blitz**, a series of night raids by Luftwaffe bombers that caused heavy casualties—more than 40,000 civilians were killed—and widespread destruction. Contrary to prewar predictions, however, the raids brought neither social breakdown nor the collapse of morale. British stoicism under fire won many admirers in the neutral US.



### Going underground

During the Blitz, thousands of Londoners spent the night in Underground stations to shelter from the bombing.

In 1940, **Franklin D. Roosevelt** stood for and won a third term in office. Before the election, Roosevelt had made his hostility to Nazi Germany and Japan clear. He had begun rearmament and introduced a measure of conscription, but he was aware of the antiwar feeling among people in

the US. In a “fireside chat” on radio, Roosevelt told Americans their country was to become the “**arsenal of democracy**,” its factories providing the arms for Britain to fight the Axis.

### Supermarine Spitfire

The Spitfire, the RAF's most famous fighter aircraft of World War II, could match the performance of the German Messerschmitt 109.

